

ATYPICAL/DYSPLASTIC NEVI

AT A GLANCE

- Prevalence among Caucasian young adults roughly 10 percent; varies by population
- Flat (totally or partially), large (>5 mm) lesions with irregular shape, indistinct borders, and variable pigmentation
- Risk markers for melanoma and potential precursors of melanoma
- Most frequent on sun-exposed areas, especially intermittently exposed sites such as the back
- Associated with large numbers of common acquired nevi
- Majority of lesions will involute and disappear over time
- Histologic features include presence of an immature or disordered growth pattern, lymphocytic host response, and random cytologic atypia in melanocytes

The usual clinical criteria for the diagnosis of a dysplastic nevus (DN) are two obligate features:

1. Diameter in one dimension at least 5 mm
2. A prominent flat component

Plus two of the following three additional features:

- Irregular, asymmetric outline
- Indistinct borders
- Variable pigmentation

Histologically, DNs show an immature or disordered growth pattern, a lymphocytic host response, and random cytologic atypia in melanocytes.

Both clinical and histologic criteria for dysplastic nevi are reproducible across observers.

Most epidemiologic data on DN's come from studies of melanoma etiology. In nearly every study assessing melanoma risk associated with DN's, these nevi are linked to an increased risk of melanoma. Clinical diagnosis of DN has typically been used as the risk factor in these analyses. Approximately 10 percent of adults of northern European descent have DN's, based on multiple case-control studies of melanoma risk. Prevalence in control populations across studies ranges from 7 to 24 percent, with variation attributed to geographic region, control selection methods, and differences in diagnostic criteria. Despite these variations, the findings are remarkably consistent.

Limited data exist on the population prevalence of DN's, and geographic and racial differences are likely. One early cross-sectional study in a general population supports this variability.